

FLYING BOATS

THE SLOW RATE OF DEVELOPMENT of flying boats in the 1920s and 1930s reflected a lack of funding for development of new aircraft. The ability to take off and land using any reasonably smooth stretch of water made flying boats an obvious choice for exploratory flights or airline services outside the technologically advanced areas of Europe and North America. They were also a reassuring form of transportation for passengers worried about flying over oceans. The large “boat” hull could provide spacious accommodation, offering a chance to compete with ocean liners for the luxury market. The big four-engined monoplanes that flourished on long-distance routes in the late 1930s – such as the Boeing 314, Martin 130, Sikorsky S-42, and Short Empire boats – were fine machines, even if they proved unable to match the next generation of landplanes.



SHORT C-CLASS

The Cassiopeia is shown being loaded at Southampton for the first passenger and airmail flight service from England to Africa.

Boeing Model 314 Clipper



The Boeing Model 314 Clipper was arguably the finest flying boat ever built and for over 30 years the largest commercial aircraft. Based on the giant but unsuccessful XB-15 bomber, the Model 314 featured four passenger cabins on two different levels, some of which could be sleeping areas. With flush toilets and even, if required, a bridal suite, the Model 314 was the epitome of luxury. Pan American commenced mail and transatlantic passenger services in May 1939. Of the 12 Model 314s built, three were used by the British Overseas Airways Corporation (BOAC), and the rest were requisitioned off Pan Am by the US military, for wartime operations as far afield as North Africa and Southeast Asia.

ENGINE 4 x 1,200hp Wright Double Cyclone 14-cylinder radial

WINGSPAN 152ft (46.3m) **LENGTH** 106ft (32.3m)

TOP SPEED 183mph (294kph) **CREW** 6–10

PASSENGERS 40–74

Caproni Ca 60 Transaero



One of the most extraordinary aircraft ever built, the philosophy behind the Transaero's design was the more wings the better. Described as a Triple Hydro-Triplane, this amazing machine had no less than three sets of triplane wings and eight engines in tractor and pusher modes.

ENGINE 8 x 400hp Liberty V 12

WINGSPAN 100ft (30.5m) **LENGTH** 77ft (23.5m)

TOP SPEED 81mph (130kph) **CREW** up to 4

PASSENGERS 100

Dornier Do 26

The last and most graceful of the long line of Dornier flying boats, the advanced Do 26 first flew in May 1938. Ordered as mailplanes by Lufthansa, two were used briefly on the South Atlantic route before war intervened. Only six were built, and these were converted into Do 26D military transports.



ENGINE 4 x 880hp Junkers Jumo 205D diesel

WINGSPAN 98ft 5in (30m) **LENGTH** 80ft 9in (24.6m)

TOP SPEED 201mph (323kph) **CREW** 12

PASSENGERS 12 fully equipped soldiers

Dornier Do J Wal

With the 1919 Versailles peace treaty restrictions on German aircraft manufacture, Professor Claudius Dornier built his Type J Wal (“Whale”) in Italy. The first example flew in 1922, and over 300 were built. The Wal was used for many long-distance pioneering flights.



ENGINE 2 x 360hp Rolls-Royce Eagle IX mounted in tandem

WINGSPAN 74ft (22.5m) **LENGTH** 80ft 9in (24.6m)

TOP SPEED 201mph (324kph) **CREW** 2

PASSENGERS 9–14